

Communication and Multimedia Arts as an Applied Social Science

Every day, billions of messages are sent, received, interpreted, and ignored. A news report shapes public opinion. A social media post sparks a movement. An advertisement convinces someone to buy a product. A film makes an audience laugh or cry. Communication is not merely the exchange of information. It is the process by which meaning is created, shared, and contested. In the digital age, communication has expanded beyond traditional media (print, radio, television) to include multimedia platforms (social media, streaming, interactive web content, virtual reality). As an applied social science, communication and multimedia studies draw from psychology (how people process messages), sociology (how media shape society), linguistics (how language creates meaning), and political science (how media influence power and democracy). Understanding communication means understanding how societies produce, distribute, and consume meaning – and how to do so ethically and effectively.

This reading material examines communication and multimedia studies as applied social sciences, explores the key functions of communication and multimedia, analyzes major communication theories, describes effective communication and multimedia skills, and outlines career pathways in the field.

Part 1: Communication and Multimedia Studies as Applied Social Sciences

Communication is not just a skill; it is a field of scientific inquiry. Communication and multimedia studies examine how humans create, transmit, and interpret messages across various contexts – interpersonal, organizational, mass media, and digital platforms. As an applied social science, this field uses research to solve real-world problems: How can a public health campaign reduce smoking? How can a news organization maintain trust? How can a social media platform reduce the spread of misinformation? The answers come from systematic study, not intuition alone.

What Is Communication and Multimedia Studies?

Communication studies is the academic discipline that examines how humans use messages to create meaning across various contexts (interpersonal, group, organizational, mass communication). **Multimedia studies** extends this focus to digital and interactive platforms, including social media, video games, streaming content, virtual reality, and convergent media (where traditional and digital media blend).

Communication and Multimedia as Applied Social Sciences

Feature	Explanation
Draws on theory	Uses psychological, sociological, and linguistic theories to explain how messages create meaning
Uses systematic methods	Applies content analysis, surveys, experiments, and audience research to study communication effects
Evidence-based	Informs media practice (journalism, advertising, public relations) with research findings
Action-oriented	Aims to improve communication effectiveness, ethical practice, and media literacy
Interdisciplinary	Integrates knowledge from psychology, sociology, linguistics, political science, and technology studies

Communication as a Social Science vs. Communication as a Skill

Dimension	Communication as Social Science	Communication as Skill
Focus	How and why communication works; effects on individuals and society	How to communicate effectively (public speaking, writing, design)

Methods	Research, theory building, empirical analysis	Practice, rehearsal, feedback, application
Outcome	Understanding of communication processes	Competence in communication tasks
Example question	Does media violence cause aggression in children?	How do I deliver an effective persuasive speech?

Part 2: Key Functions of Communication and Multimedia

Communication serves multiple functions in society. These functions apply to traditional media (print, broadcast) and digital/multimedia platforms.

Functions of Communication

Function	Explanation	Example
Information dissemination	Sharing facts, news, and knowledge	A news report about a typhoon's path and expected impact
Persuasion	Influencing attitudes, beliefs, or behaviors	A public health campaign encouraging vaccination
Entertainment	Providing pleasure, relaxation, and enjoyment	A streaming series, a video game, a comedy podcast
Social interaction	Building and maintaining relationships	Texting a friend, commenting on a social media post, video calling family
Education	Teaching skills, knowledge, and values	An online tutorial, a documentary, an educational YouTube channel

Function	Explanation	Example
Cultural transmission	Passing down values, beliefs, and traditions	A film that explores Filipino family values; a song that preserves a folk story
Surveillance	Monitoring the environment for threats or opportunities	Weather alerts, traffic reports, financial news
Agenda-setting	Influencing what people think about (not what to think)	News coverage shaping which issues the public considers important

Functions Unique to Multimedia and Digital Platforms

Function	Explanation	Example
Interactivity	Users can respond, participate, and co-create content	Comment sections, live streams, polls, user-generated content
Personalization	Content is tailored to individual preferences	Algorithm-driven feeds (TikTok, YouTube recommendations)
Convergence	Multiple media forms (text, audio, video) are combined	A news website with articles, video interviews, podcasts, and interactive graphics
Virality	Content spreads rapidly through social networks	A meme shared across Twitter, Facebook, and Instagram within hours
Archiving	Content is stored and searchable indefinitely	YouTube history, Instagram archives, TikTok saved posts

Part 3: Major Communication and Multimedia Theories

Communication theories explain how messages create meaning, how media affect individuals and society, and how people interpret and respond to communication.

Interpersonal and Group Communication Theories

Symbolic Interactionism

- *Key Thinkers:* George Herbert Mead, Herbert Blumer
- *Core Idea:* Meaning is created through social interaction and shared symbols (language, gestures). People interpret symbols based on shared social meanings, and these interpretations shape behavior. Meaning is not fixed; it emerges from interaction.
- *Application:* Understanding how families, teams, or online communities develop shared meanings, inside jokes, rituals, and norms over time.

Social Penetration Theory

- *Key Thinkers:* Irwin Altman, Dalmas Taylor
- *Core Idea:* Relationships develop from superficial to intimate through self-disclosure – the process of revealing personal information. As disclosure increases in breadth (number of topics) and depth (intimacy of topics), relationships grow closer. This is often compared to peeling an onion: layers are removed gradually.
- *Application:* Understanding friendship development; online dating communication; why some relationships remain superficial while others become deeply intimate.

Uncertainty Reduction Theory

- *Key Thinkers:* Charles Berger
- *Core Idea:* People seek to reduce uncertainty about others through communication, especially in initial interactions. When strangers meet, they experience uncertainty about how the other will behave. They communicate to gather information, predict behavior, and reduce anxiety. The more uncertainty, the more communication occurs.
- *Application:* First impressions; intercultural communication; online dating profiles; job interviews; international exchange programs.

Uses and Gratifications Theory

- *Key Thinkers:* Elihu Katz, Jay Blumler
- *Core Idea:* Audiences are active, not passive. They choose media to satisfy specific needs or "gratifications": information (to learn), entertainment (to relax), social connection (to feel connected to others), and identity (to reinforce values or self-concept). Unlike earlier theories that asked "What do media do to people?" this theory asks "What do people do with media?"
- *Application:* Explaining why different people choose different media (TikTok vs. news podcasts vs. video games); why someone might watch a comforting childhood film when sad.

Mass Communication and Media Effects Theories

Agenda-Setting Theory

- *Key Thinkers:* Maxwell McCombs, Donald Shaw
- *Core Idea:* Media do not tell people what to think, but they tell people what to think about. By giving repeated attention to certain issues (e.g., climate change, crime, the economy), media signal to audiences that these issues are important. The issues that receive more coverage become public priorities.
- *Application:* Explaining why certain issues become public priorities; why politicians focus on issues that dominate news coverage.

Framing Theory

- *Key Thinkers:* Erving Goffman, Robert Entman
- *Core Idea:* Media present events within a "frame" that influences interpretation. The same event can be framed differently – a protest can be framed as a "riot" (criminalizing participants) or a "demonstration" (legitimizing their cause). Frames select some aspects of reality and make them more salient while obscuring others.
- *Application:* Analyzing how different news outlets cover the same event differently; understanding political spin and propaganda.

Cultivation Theory

- *Key Thinkers:* George Gerbner
- *Core Idea:* Long-term exposure to media (especially television) shapes viewers' perceptions of reality to match media portrayals. Heavy viewers come to believe the world is more like the media world – more violent, more dangerous, more extreme – than it actually is. The effect is gradual and cumulative.
- *Application:* Explaining why heavy TV viewers overestimate crime rates or violence in society; understanding how media shape our sense of risk and safety.

Spiral of Silence

- *Key Thinkers:* Elisabeth Noelle-Neumann
- *Core Idea:* People are less likely to express opinions they believe are unpopular, fearing social isolation. They monitor the climate of opinion. If they perceive their view as losing ground, they remain silent. This silence makes the dominant view appear even more dominant, causing more people to remain silent – a spiral effect.
- *Application:* Explaining why minority viewpoints may disappear from public discussion (online and offline); why people hesitate to post controversial opinions on social media.

Two-Step Flow Theory

- *Key Thinkers:* Paul Lazarsfeld, Elihu Katz
- *Core Idea:* Media effects are not direct. Instead, messages flow from media to opinion leaders (informed, influential individuals), and then from opinion leaders to the wider public. Opinion leaders interpret, filter, and amplify media messages. This challenges the earlier "hypodermic needle" model (media inject ideas directly into passive audiences).
- *Application:* Explaining how influencers shape audience opinions; word-of-mouth marketing; why personal recommendations are more persuasive than advertisements.

Digital and Multimedia Theories

Networked Publics (danah boyd)

- *Core Idea:* Digital spaces are not just audiences but interconnected publics where people gather, speak, and act. Unlike traditional mass audiences (passive receivers), networked publics allow interaction, conversation, and collective action. These spaces

have unique properties: persistence (content lasts), replicability (content can be copied), scalability (content can reach large audiences), and searchability (content can be found).

- *Application:* Understanding social media activism (e.g., #MeToo movement); how online communities form around shared interests; how hashtags create temporary publics around events or causes.

Information Cascades

- *Core Idea:* People imitate others' behavior online, leading to rapid spread of information (or misinformation). When individuals observe others adopting a belief or action, they infer that the belief is correct or the action is appropriate – even if their own information suggests otherwise. This can cause rapid, self-reinforcing spread of ideas, products, or rumors. A cascade begins when a few early adopters influence others, who influence more, creating a snowball effect.
- *Application:* Explaining viral trends (dance challenges, memes); fake news spread (false stories going viral before corrections); echo chambers (reinforcing existing beliefs within a network); product adoption (why certain items suddenly become popular).

Media Richness Theory

- *Core Idea:* Communication media vary in their ability to convey complex information. Rich media (video calls, face-to-face conversation) can convey multiple cues (tone, expression, gesture), provide immediate feedback, and use natural language. Lean media (text messages, emails) convey fewer cues and slower feedback. The theory recommends matching media richness to message complexity: use rich media for ambiguous or emotional messages; use lean media for simple, routine messages.
- *Application:* Choosing the right medium for a message (e.g., delivering bad news by phone or video call, not text); explaining why teams use video conferencing for complex discussions but email for routine updates; understanding why misunderstandings occur when using lean media for emotional topics.

Participatory Culture

- *Core Idea:* Fans and users actively create and share content, not just consume it. In participatory culture, the boundaries between producers and consumers blur. Low barriers to artistic expression, strong support for sharing creations, informal mentorship, and social connections among participants characterize this culture. This contrasts with earlier mass media models where a few producers created content for passive audiences.
- *Application:* Fan fiction (writing stories based on existing media); reaction videos (responding to content); memes (creating and remixing cultural symbols); TikTok dances

(choreographing and sharing movements); Reddit communities (discussing, voting on, and contributing content); collaborative knowledge projects (Wikipedia, fan wikis).

Multimedia and Digital Skills

Skill	Description	Tools/Platforms
Content creation	Producing text, images, audio, and video for digital platforms	Canva, Adobe Creative Suite, CapCut, Premiere Pro
Social media management	Creating, scheduling, and analyzing content across social platforms	Meta Business Suite, Hootsuite, Later, TikTok Creator Tools
Basic graphic design	Creating visual content for communication (posters, infographics, social graphics)	Canva, Photoshop, Illustrator, Figma
Video and audio production	Shooting, editing, and publishing video or audio content	Premiere Pro, Final Cut, Audacity, GarageBand, DaVinci Resolve
Data storytelling	Using data visualization to communicate insights	Excel, Tableau, Google Data Studio, Flourish
Search engine optimization (SEO)	Optimizing content to rank higher in search results	Google Analytics, SEMrush, Ahrefs, keyword research
Analytics and metrics	Measuring and interpreting audience engagement and reach	Google Analytics, Meta Insights, YouTube Studio, TikTok Analytics
Basic HTML and CMS	Understanding web publishing platforms	WordPress, Wix, Squarespace, basic HTML/CSS

Soft Skills for Communication Professionals

Skill	Description
Adaptability	Adjusting messages and strategies for different platforms, audiences, and changing circumstances
Critical thinking	Evaluating sources, identifying bias, and making ethical decisions about content
Collaboration	Working effectively with designers, developers, marketers, and other professionals
Emotional intelligence	Recognizing and managing one's own emotions and those of others in communication
Ethical judgment	Balancing truth-telling with privacy, harm reduction, and social responsibility

Part 5: Career Pathways in Communication and Multimedia Studies

Communication and multimedia graduates work in media production, journalism, advertising, public relations, corporate communication, digital marketing, and emerging fields such as user experience (UX) writing and content strategy.

Journalism and News Media

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Reporter/Journalist	News organizations (print, broadcast, digital)	Researching stories; conducting interviews; writing articles or scripts

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Editor	Newsrooms, publishing houses	Reviewing and revising content; fact-checking; managing writers
News Anchor	Broadcast news, online news channels	Delivering news on camera; interviewing guests; writing scripts
Multimedia Journalist	Digital news platforms	Reporting using text, video, audio, and photos; producing content for multiple platforms
Fact-Checker	News organizations, independent fact-checking groups	Verifying claims; researching sources; correcting misinformation

Advertising, Public Relations, and Marketing

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Copywriter	Advertising agencies, marketing departments	Writing persuasive copy for ads, websites, social media, and email campaigns
Public Relations Specialist	PR agencies, corporations, non-profits	Managing media relations; writing press releases; crisis communication
Social Media Manager	Brands, agencies, organizations	Creating and scheduling content; engaging with audiences; analyzing metrics
Brand Strategist	Advertising agencies, marketing firms	Developing brand voice and messaging; conducting audience research
Media Planner	Advertising agencies	Deciding which media channels (TV, social, print) to use for campaigns

Digital Content and Multimedia Production

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Content Creator	Self-employed, media companies, brands	Producing video, audio, or written content for YouTube, TikTok, podcasts, or blogs
Video Editor	Production companies, media agencies, brands	Editing video content for social media, commercials, films, or online courses
Podcast Producer	Podcast networks, brands, self-employed	Recording, editing, and publishing audio content; managing distribution
Graphic Designer	Design agencies, marketing departments, freelance	Creating visual content for print and digital media (logos, posters, social graphics)
Multimedia Artist	Gaming companies, animation studios, film production	Creating animations, visual effects, or interactive content

Corporate and Organizational Communication

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Corporate Communications Specialist	Corporations, non-profits, government agencies	Writing internal newsletters; managing employee communications; handling press inquiries
Content Writer	Tech companies, e-commerce, agencies	Writing blog posts, website copy, email newsletters, and white papers
UX Writer	Tech companies, software firms	Writing microcopy (button labels, error messages, onboarding flows) for apps and websites

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Internal Communications Manager	Large organizations	Communicating with employees through intranet, email, and town halls
Speechwriter	Government officials, corporate executives, politicians	Writing speeches for public delivery; adapting messages for oral presentation

Emerging and Specialized Careers

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks
Influencer Marketing Specialist	Agencies, brands	Identifying and managing relationships with social media influencers; tracking campaign performance
Community Manager	Brands, online platforms, gaming companies	Moderating online communities; engaging with users; managing feedback
Data Storyteller	Media organizations, think tanks, corporate communications	Creating data visualizations and narratives to communicate complex information
Podcast Host	Media companies, self-employed	Researching topics; interviewing guests; hosting and promoting episodes
Esports Commentator	Gaming organizations, streaming platforms	Providing live commentary for competitive gaming events

Communication and Multimedia in the Philippines

Information	Details
Major employers	ABS-CBN, GMA, TV5, Rappler, Inquirer, Philippine Star; advertising agencies (McCann, Ogilvy, Ace Saatchi & Saatchi); digital agencies; corporate communications departments; freelance content creation
Industry trends	Growth of digital content creation (YouTube, TikTok); demand for social media managers; rise of podcasting; need for fact-checking and media literacy
Skills in demand	Video editing, social media management, SEO, copywriting, data analytics, basic graphic design
Professional organizations	Philippine Association of Communication Educators (PACE); Kapisanan ng mga Brodkaster ng Pilipinas (KBP); Internet and Mobile Marketing Association of the Philippines (IMMAP)

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Communication studies	The academic discipline examining how humans use messages to create meaning across contexts
Multimedia studies	The study of digital and interactive platforms, including social media, video games, and convergent media
Agenda-setting theory	Media do not tell people what to think but what to think about
Framing theory	Media present events within a "frame" that influences interpretation
Cultivation theory	Long-term media exposure shapes perceptions of reality to match media portrayals
Uses and gratifications theory	Audiences actively choose media to satisfy specific needs
Two-step flow theory	Media effects are mediated by opinion leaders who interpret messages for others
Participatory culture	Fans and users actively create and share content, not just consume it
Convergence	Multiple media forms (text, audio, video) are combined into a single platform or message
Networked publics	Digital spaces where people gather, speak, and act as interconnected publics

Review Questions

1. Define communication and multimedia studies as applied social sciences. How do they differ from communication as a skill?
2. Explain the three functions of communication and give an example for each.
3. Identify three major communication theories from Part 3. For each theory, state the core idea and one real-world application.
4. Explain the difference between Agenda-Setting Theory and Framing Theory. How do they both relate to media influence?
5. What is the Spiral of Silence? How does it apply to social media environments?
6. List three effective communication skills and three multimedia skills from Part 4. For each skill, explain why it matters.
7. Choose three career pathways from Part 5. For each, state the work setting and one typical task.
8. What is Uses and Gratifications Theory? How does it differ from older "hypodermic needle" models of media effects (which assumed audiences passively accept media messages)?
9. Describe the concept of "participatory culture." Provide one example from your own media use.
10. Application question: A brand wants to launch a new product targeting Filipino teenagers. Using concepts from this lesson (functions of communication, theories, and skills), design a basic communication strategy. What platforms would you use? What type of content would you create? What theory would guide your approach?